

6. Helping with Moving About

Fig 10.



Fig 11.

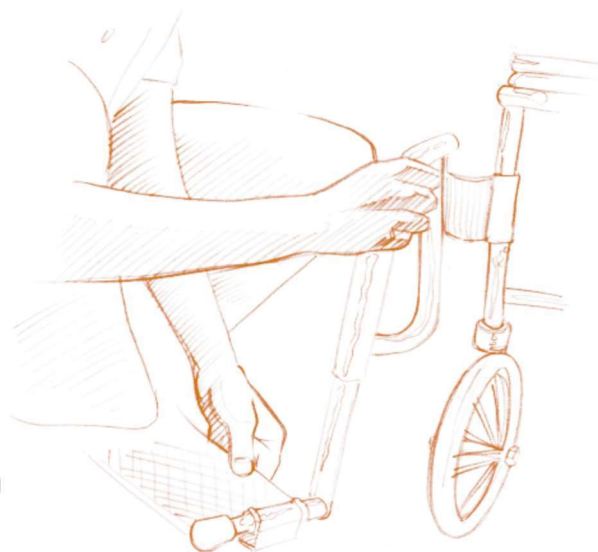


Fig 12.



Fig 13.



Fig 14.



Fig 15.



Fig 16.



BODY MECHANICS (USING YOUR BODY CORRECTLY)

Body mechanics refers to the way you use your body during movement. It is especially important when you are doing something that can strain your joints. Paying attention to body mechanics during lifting or bending will help to prevent injury.

What you need to know

The most important aspect of your own body mechanics is knowledge of your body's abilities. Pay attention to your own limitations. There are three terms you need to understand.

- Your center of gravity is located at the middle of your body, about your hips.
- Your line of balance is an imaginary line, from head to foot, that divides your body into two equal parts.
- The base of support is the space between your feet that bears the weight of your body. (See figure 10).
- When moving or lifting a heavy object, reduce the strain on your back by keeping your line of balance close to your center of gravity. Bend your knees instead of your back to keep you from leaning forward or backward.
- Open the distance between your feet to broaden your base of support. This distributes the extra weight you are bearing or lifting and decreases the strain on your back muscles.
- Get close to the object you are moving. Make sure your center of gravity is as close to the object as possible.
- Use your arm and leg muscles, not your back, to do the work. When you are using your arms, keep the load close to your body. Also, your greatest lift power comes with pushing rather than pulling.
- Look at where you are and where you want to go. Think through the movement before you proceed.

LIFTING

When lifting a person, a few basic techniques done correctly can help prevent injury to everyone involved.

- Make sure obstacles or barriers are moved out of the way.

- Talk through the lift step by step so everyone involved understands the direction and purpose of the movement.
- Count to three before the movement begins, so everyone moves at the same time.
- Take a deep breath before you start and breathe regularly while lifting.
- Turn with your feet, pivot or step to avoid twisting your body.
- Always do the least amount of work to achieve your move. Have the person in bed help you as much as possible.

MOVING SOMEONE FROM BED TO CHAIR

Getting out of bed can help lift someone's spirits and help to prevent bed sores.

How you can offer care

- Take your time. A person who has been lying in bed for any length of time may feel dizzy when sitting up.
- Make sure the dizziness has passed before making the move.
- Have all your equipment ready for the move.
- Put bed brakes on and lower the bed to chair height if that is possible.
- Place the chair at the head of the bed, facing the foot. If you are using a wheelchair, make sure the brakes are on and, when possible, remove the armrest and foot pedal closest to the bed. (See figure 11)
- Make sure you and the person both have on non-slip footwear.
- Raise the head of the bed as high as it will go.
- Move the person's legs over the side of the bed, then help the person slide forward to the edge of the bed. The feet should touch the floor or footstool (See figure 12).
- Bend your knees and lean towards the person, keeping your back straight.
- Put the person's arms around your back, not around your neck. For someone too weak to grasp, place the arms over your shoulders with head resting on your shoulder. (See figure 13)
- Place your arms around the person's lower back or use the waist band, a turning sheet, towel or transfer belt around the back so you can support the person.

- Rock gently for momentum and count to three. In one continuous movement, stand, pivot, (Figure 11), shuffle together backward until the chair touches the back of the knees, and lower the person into the chair. (See figures 14 and 15)
- Replace wheelchair armrest and foot pedal.

WALKING

Although the person may be able to stand and walk, help may still be needed to prevent falls. Some people will be able to use a cane or walking device while others will need support.

How you can offer care

- The most important thing for you to do is prevent your loved one from falling while walking.
- Move all obstacles from your path. Have a chair nearby in case the person needs a rest.
- Make sure both of you are wearing non-skid footwear.
- Provide your support on the person's weaker side. If a cane is used, have the person hold it on the stronger side. This will keep the weight on the side that can support it.
- Stand beside and slightly behind the person, facing the same direction. When necessary, remind the person to stand tall and to look ahead, not down at the floor.
- Put your arm around the person's waist and use your other hand to hold the person's elbow or hand. Stay close so that your entire body gives support. (See figure 16)
- Try using a belt or folded blanket around the person's waist so you can hang on to it to give added support.

7. Toileting

For some people, the need for help with toileting can be very embarrassing. This is particularly true for someone who is confined to bed.

What you need to know

- The person may need help to use the toilet, a commode, a urinal or a bedpan depending on mobility.
- When helping with toileting needs, respect patient's dignity.
- Be sensitive to the need for privacy.